

Audeze LCD-i3

Impressive planar magnetic monitors

Audeze headphones have always been a favourite here at the Digit test lab and the new LCD-i3 cements our liking for this audiophile-grade brand even more. Priced at ₹79,990, it mesmerised us with its sound which is why it ended up being the winner in the Wired IEM segment in our Digit Zero1 awards. Let's delve into these earphones further.

Build and design

The Audeze LCD-i3 earphones come packaged in a hard, textured plastic box. The box features a wide array of angled ear hooks and eartips of different sizes which ensure that you get a good fit. However, despite donning the right size of both, the hooks and eartips, we found the fit to be rather flimsy owing to the weight of these earphones. They felt moderately secure when we were sitting still in one place, but walking about would cause them to loosen and sometimes pop out.

The multiple cables allow users to connect them to a wide number of devices. They can be used passively via the standard 3.5mm cable, the Lightning cable for iPhones or the Bluetooth module. We would have loved it even more if these cables were tangle-free though. The cables come with a standard 2-pin connector to connect to the IEMs.

The Audeze LCD-i3 are open-back earphones, so, sound does leak both in and out. The passive isolation is extremely poor, so, office environments, public trains and buses and in general, an outdoors environment are not ideal. The i3 sports a 30mm transducer which utilises a Neodymium N50 magnet. This magnet is housed inside a plastic shell with a semi glossy finish. A silver aluminium mesh grill sits directly underneath this and the overall look is premium. The plastic chassis is a good choice since a metal one would have deteriorated the comfort and fit even more. Something we missed sorely were foam



tips which we think should have been included at this exorbitant price point. The LCD-i3 also juts out of the ear considerably and looks rather odd.

Features

The lightning cable for iPhones has Audeze's cypher tech which is basically its proprietary DSP. Its DAC converts at 24 bit and it is also compatible with the Audeze DSP app which lets users customise the EQ intricately. You can utilise Audeze's app to access various premade DSP modes as well. The cable also has a microphone and in-line controller.

The Bluetooth module, sporting Bluetooth 5.0 standard, similarly comes with cypher tech and an in-line controller. This module supports hi-res audio codecs such as AptX and AptX HD and has a respectable 8-hour long battery life. We managed to squeeze out around 7 hours and 15 minutes at about 60 per cent volume.

The analog 3.5mm connector cable, however, does not include the DSP unfortunately. We evaluated the i3 with both the 3.5mm cable and the Bluetooth module in this review.

Performance

The Audeze LCD-i3 retrieves the detail in audio exceptionally well. The stock experience, without any tweaking the cypher tech allows you, is flat and will please the most stringent audiophiles.

The bass is tight, controlled and sufficiently punchy. Kick drums and bass guitars sound fantastic and the sound is never too jarring to the mids. The separation from the low mids is excellent.

The lower-mids are sometimes a bit too weighty for our liking and female vocals suffer slightly due to this. However, the rest of the frequency range in the mids sounds luscious and forward.

The highs is where the Audeze LCD-i3 excel. They extend quite a bit but do not, at any point, sound sibilant or tinny and mostly sound luscious and full. The extended highs make the tracks significantly more dynamic, adding oomph to pop or rock tracks such as *Something From Nothing* by The Foo Fighters.

The soundstage, as expected from open-back earphones, is extremely spacious. Imaging is also excellent and on certain tracks such as AKFG's *Blue Train*, you will feel a sense of closeness to the instruments. Being open-back has shattered the limitations IEMs usually stumble upon. The result is a remarkable airy quality which sounds ultra-realistic.

Bottomline

If budget is not an issue for you, the Audeze LCD-i3 are one of the best pair of IEMs you can find on the market today. If you're an audiophile and mostly listen to music within the confines of your home or studio, these IEMs deliver life-like, balanced sound quality that brings out intricate details and nuances in tracks, unlike traditional BA IEMs. The planar magnetic tech coupled with the open-back design delivers airy, realistic sound. Priced at ₹79,900, these IEMs are on the expensive side, but they are worth every rupee and then some.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

STYLE: In-ear, semi open-back | TRANSDUCER TYPE: Planar Magnetic | MAGNETIC STRUCTURE: Fluxor magnet array | MAGNET TYPE: Neodymium N50 | DIAPHRAGM TYPE: Ultra-thin Uniforce | TRANSDUCER SIZE: 30 mm | FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 10Hz - 50kHz | IMPEDANCE: 20 ohms

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